

Personal Auto Claims Handling Procedures Manual

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Audience: Claims adjusters, claims operations, and adjudication support tools

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This manual consolidates and expands on the Claims Adjudication Guidelines with detailed operational procedure. Where this manual and the Claims Adjudication Guidelines appear to conflict, the Claims Adjudication Guidelines control on matters of coverage determination; this manual controls on matters of process and documentation detail.

1. Claim Intake

1.1 Channels

A claim may be reported by phone, through the policyholder portal, by an agent on the policyholder's behalf, or — for claims involving injury or significant property damage — in person at a claims office. Regardless of channel, the same intake data is captured: policy number, named insured, date and time of loss, location, a description of what happened, and whether any other party or vehicle was involved.

1.2 Immediate Triage at Intake

At intake, before full adjudication begins, the intake representative checks for immediate safety concerns (injuries requiring emergency response, a vehicle that is not safe to drive) and routes accordingly. This immediate triage is separate from, and does not substitute for, the five-step adjudication sequence in the Claims Adjudication Guidelines.

1.3 Assigning an Adjuster

Every claim is assigned to a specific adjuster of record within one business day of intake. The assigned adjuster is the one who ultimately approves, rejects, or edits-and-approves the adjudication recommendation — assignment is not a formality,

since Policy Wording Section 8.1's acknowledgment clock runs from intake regardless of when assignment happens.

2. Investigation

2.1 What "Investigation" Means Here

Investigation is the fact-gathering that feeds Steps 2 and 3 of the Claims Adjudication Guidelines (coverage evaluation and exclusion detection) — confirming what happened, matching it against the Declarations page and Policy Wording, and identifying anything that triggers the Standard Exclusions Addendum or the anomaly indicators in Adjudication Guidelines Section 3.

2.2 Sources of Investigation Evidence

- The policyholder's own claim narrative, taken at intake.
- A police or incident report, where one exists.
- An independent repair estimate.
- Photographs or documentation the policyholder or a repair shop provides.
- For a claim flagged under the SIU Fraud Indicators Guide, additional targeted inquiry consistent with that guide's escalation path.

2.3 When Investigation Is Sufficient to Proceed

Investigation is sufficient to proceed to Step 4 (payout computation) when the governing policy form version is confirmed, the applicable coverage part and its limit/deductible are confirmed from the Declarations page, and no unresolved exclusion question remains open. An unresolved exclusion question — for example, the ambiguous ride-share scenario in the Claims FAQ — means investigation is not yet sufficient, and the claim should not proceed to computation on an assumption.

3. Documentation Standards

3.1 What Belongs in the Claim File

Every claim file retains: the original intake record, all investigation evidence gathered, the specific Policy Wording and Declarations page sections relied upon, the deterministic payout computation and its inputs, and the identity and timestamp of the approving adjuster. This mirrors, and does not replace, the documentation requirement in Claims Adjudication Guidelines Section 4.

3.2 Amending a Claim File

A claim file is amended by addendum, never by editing an existing entry, once a recommendation has been drafted. This preserves the audit trail the appraisal process (Policy Wording Section 8.2) and any subrogation action (Subrogation and Litigation Hold Guide) may later depend on.

4. Quality Review

4.1 Sampling

A percentage of completed claims are sampled for quality review each month, checking specifically for: correct policy-version matching (Adjudication Guidelines Step 1, the single most common source of error), correct application of any applicable deductible waiver, and complete citation of the policy sections relied upon.

4.2 Findings and Correction

A quality-review finding that identifies a wrong-version or miscomputed claim is corrected through a formal reopening of the claim, with the correction and its basis documented as an addendum per Section 3.2 — never silently overwritten.

5. Claim Closure

A claim is closed once the approved recommendation has been communicated to the policyholder and, where applicable, payment has been issued. A closed claim may still be reopened for a documented reason — a quality-review finding, a policyholder dispute escalated through the Complaint Handling Procedure, or a subrogation development — but closure is not treated as making the record immutable, only as marking the ordinary workflow complete.

6. Escalation Paths Summary

This manual's procedures intersect with several escalation paths documented elsewhere in this corpus: SIU referral (SIU Fraud Indicators Guide), policyholder complaints (Complaint Handling Procedure), catastrophe-event triage (Catastrophe Claims Surge Protocol), and subrogation (Subrogation and Litigation Hold Guide). An adjuster should treat this manual's procedures as the default path and consult the relevant specialized document when a claim's facts trigger one of these specific situations.